

“From *Evropa* to *Gayropa*”: Exploring the Relationship Between Euroskepticism and the Rejection of Gay Men and Lesbian Women in Serbia

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Abstract

This paper examines the relationship between Euroskepticism and the rejection of gay men and lesbian women in Serbia. Drawing on Slootmaeckers’ (2023) relational and transnational approach, I argue that sexual politics in Serbia are fundamentally shaped by the geopolitical tensions surrounding EU enlargement, in which LGBT rights have become a symbolic boundary-marker between competing visions of national identity. Using data from the European Social Survey Round 11 (2023), I construct latent indices for Euroskepticism and rejection of gays and lesbians through Exploratory Factor Analysis and test their association through bivariate and multivariate linear regression. The results confirm a significant positive relationship: higher levels of Euroskepticism predict greater homonegativity, even after controlling for gender, age, education, and religiosity. Notably, religiosity exerts a considerably smaller effect than anti-EU sentiment, suggesting that homonegativity in Serbia is driven less by religious conviction than by geopolitical alignment. These findings illustrate how the EU’s top-down promotion of LGBT rights may inadvertently fuel the resistance it seeks to overcome.

Keywords: Euroskepticism, homonegativity, Serbia, European Social Survey

1. Introduction

Serbia, alongside Montenegro, is formally recognized as being at the “most advanced” stage of the EU enlargement process among Western Balkan candidates (Slootmaeckers, 2023, p. 17). At the same time, data from the European Social Survey Round 11 reveals the country exhibits some of the highest levels of rejection toward gays and lesbians in Europe (see Figure 1). This discrepancy may have appeared less problematic in the early 2000s, when discussions on the unequal citizenship status of sexual minorities were only beginning to make a timid appearance in EU legal discourse. However, by the time Serbia attained official candidacy in 2012, amidst the “full swing” of the EU’s eastern enlargement (Maycock, 2023, p. 40), the normative landscape had shifted. The protection of sexual minorities has become a pillar of the accession process for Serbia, Croatia, and Montenegro, illustrated in Article 33 of the European Parliament’s 2012 Resolution on Serbia, which explicitly calls for combating homophobia in line with EU democratic and human rights standards (Kahlina, 2013).

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To add to the tension, although full EU membership remains Serbia's official strategic goal, the country occupies an ambivalent position regarding the EU and its accession process. It remains within Russia's sphere of influence and shows levels of support for its president otherwise undetectable west of the Russian border, alongside strong opposition to NATO (Proroković, 2020, p. 197). Within this context, sexual politics become a site of contestation. For Sloodmaeckers (2023, p. 9), sexual politics are fundamentally located in the relation between the EU and the candidate countries. As such, Serbia serves as an interesting study case for these tensions: a young state formed after the dissolution of Yugoslavia, still navigating a nation-building process in which heteronormative sexuality is deeply embedded in nationalist imaginaries and Orthodox beliefs. The EU accession process has not merely functioned as a top-down mandate; rather, it has opened up a space for political mobilisation for a diverse array of actors (Kahlina, 2013) who draw on competing normative assumptions about sexuality to establish their visions of national identity and desired future.

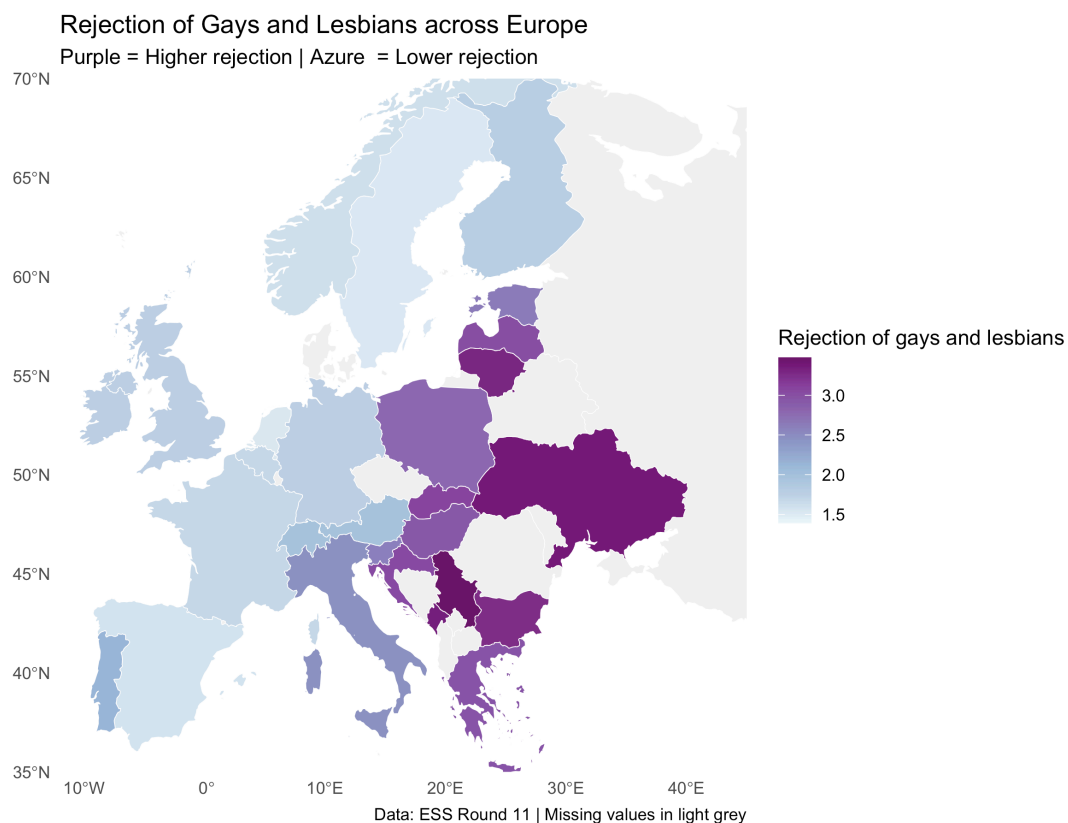


Figure 1: Spatial distribution of attitudes rejecting gays and lesbians across Europe. Own elaboration.

In this paper, adopting a relational and transnational approach (Sloodmaeckers, 2023), I explore the extent to which the social belonging of gay men and lesbian women in Serbia is perceived through the prism of an individual's support for the European Union. Analyzing data from the 2023 European Social Survey (ESS), I seek to answer the following research question (RQ): **To what extent is Euroskepticism associated with the rejection of gay**

men and lesbian women in Serbia? By doing so, I aim to contribute to contemporary sociological debates on “Europeanization” and sexual citizenship within the framework of EU-enlargement toward the Balkan countries.

2. Background: Geopolitics, sexuality, and national identity in Serbia

To understand the backlash against the “Europeanization” of the post-Yugoslav region, it becomes necessary to review the geopolitical relations of Serbia and Russia. This section traces how Russia’s influence on Serbia and the nationalist instrumentalization of sexuality have converged to produce the conditions under which LGBT rights became a contested signifier of European integration. This link is discursively sustained by the myth of a “centuries-old friendship and brotherhood”, wherein Russia presents itself as an historical protector of Serbia’s interests (Aghayev, 2017), acting as both an ideological patron and a symbolic foil for national identity. As ancient as it appears, the myth has been strategically revitalized in recent years. Following the “Color Revolutions” in post-Soviet republics, Russian opinion, mobilized by Putin, moved from the cautious optimism of the early 2000s toward a deep-seated skepticism that views the EU as a potentially hostile power (Foxall, 2019). This shift found fertile ground in Serbia, where NATO’s military 1999 intervention and the initiation of the independent Kosovo project had already created a lasting resentment (Proroković, 2020). As a result, today Serbia remains a unique outlier of “Russophilia” in Europe, with overwhelming popular support for Russia and Putin rather than Western institutions like NATO. Consequently, Proroković (2020) argues that Russia has effectively turned Serbia into a dam to stop or at least slow down the expansion of NATO.

The construction of contemporary Serbian identity is rooted in the post-1991 dissolution of Yugoslavia, a period characterized by nationalization processes and struggles over self-determination that saw new identities increasingly constituted in ethnic terms (Kahlina, 2013). Within this framework, gender roles and sexuality became foundational to the nation-building project; normative assumptions regarding reproductive heterosexuality and traditional gender divisions were instrumentalized as critical markers of ethnic homogeneity. Under dominant nationalist discourses, reproductive heterosexuality was framed not merely as a private matter, but as a vital political instrument for securing the biological survival and potency of the nation (Žarkov, 2007, as cited in Kahlina, 2013). Consequently, homophobia emerged as the functional glue necessary to hold a traditionalist national identity together against perceived threats to this ethnic purity (Maycock, 2019).

The collapse of communism and the accelerated socio-political shifts that followed facilitated a transition from secular transnationalism to a mounting tension between secular and religious nationalism. In this framework, local leaders often instrumentalize religious elements, incorporating them into their ideological matrices to secure new forms of political capital (Juergensmeyer, 2008). In Serbia, this cultural logic of nationalism has been strongly supported by dominant religious communities that instrumentalize specific norms of gender and sexuality. In particular, the Serbian Orthodox Church led by Patriarch Porfirije, a close collaborator of Putin, has gained significant media attention and has been recognized as a primary moral authority (Kahlina, 2013). Nevertheless, while there is a strong correlation

between adherence to the Serbian Orthodox Church and homophobic attitudes, religiosity alone is not sufficient to explain homophobia in the former Yugoslav states (Maycock, 2019).

The process of EU accession in the Balkan region has facilitated the transformation of sexual citizenship into a contested terrain, where struggles over liberal pluralism, “European-ness,” and national identity take place (Kahlina, 2013). By positioning LGBT rights as a litmus test for Western modernity, the enlargement process has created a rift that external actors have been quick to exploit. Since 2012, Russian statecraft has revitalized these domestic tensions by utilizing the “Western gay menace” to counteract Western influence (Cooper-Cunningham, 2025). This strategy has given rise to the term “Gayropa” as a key geopolitical signifier of the civilizational divide between the EU and Russia (Foxall, 2019). Within this context, the rejection of homosexual rights in Serbia has evolved into a proclamation of geopolitical resistance, allowing domestic actors to align their traditionalist moral authority with a broader Russian-led defense against perceived Western decadence.

3. Theory

The promotion of LGBT rights has become a constitutive element of European identity, increasingly centered in the European Union’s foreign and enlargement policies as a defense of universal fundamental rights. Within this framework, for Lekova (2017) economic integration is inextricably tied to a question of morality, where the EU is positioned as a primary defender of human rights. This political process contributes to a popularized image of the EU as “exceptionally good” at protecting sexual minorities, subjecting candidate countries to what Kulpa (2014) describes as a leveraged pedagogy (Slootmaeckers, 2023, p. 8).

However, scholars have critiqued this top-down conceptualization of Europeanization. While the accession process often facilitates the adoption of new laws, the literature frequently adopts an overly optimistic progress undertone that takes the EU’s LGBT-friendliness for granted (Slootmaeckers, 2023). In reality, LGBT rights are not deeply rooted within the EU *acquis*, leaving them in a state of ambiguity that allows for significant political contestation and negotiation (Mos, 2020 as cited in Slootmaeckers, 2023). Precisely because these rights play such a symbolic role in boundary-making processes, the association between the EU and sexual liberalism has been transformed into a rhetorical vehicle for those offering alternative cultural paradigms (Ayoub & Paternotte, 2014). By treating LGBT rights as a non-negotiable condition of membership, the EU’s top-down promotion has inadvertently sparked resistance, fueling state-sponsored and political homophobia within candidate and new member states (Slootmaeckers, 2023; Thiel, 2022) by engaging in what Cooper-Cunningham (2021) labels “heteronormative internationalism”. This process places traditional family values at the center of foreign policy, allowing domestic actors to project their rejection of EU norms as a legitimate defense of national sovereignty on the global stage (Slootmaeckers, 2023).

To gain a more comprehensive understanding of the tensions surrounding sexual minorities within Serbia’s EU accession process, I follow Slootmaeckers’ (2023) relational and transnational approach. While this perspective draws on norm diffusion theory, it also critically departs from it by rejecting the assumption that moral norms are transmitted unilaterally

from Western Europe to third countries. Instead, it conceptualizes norms and values as emerging from interactions among actors embedded in broader geopolitical contexts. From this viewpoint, EU values are not pre-given or fixed, but are continuously negotiated through the EU enlargement process in the course of exchanges between the EU and candidate countries (Emirbayer, 1997, cited in Slootmaeckers, 2023, p. 10).

Under this framework, a significant portion of the Serbian public perceive EU enlargement as a symbolic bridge to sexual liberalism that threatens domestic traditionalist identities. Thus, if LGBT rights are framed as the primary signifier of Western “interference”, then opposition to the EU should correlate with a rejection of the minority groups that have become the scapegoat of that integration process. This leads to the primary hypothesis of this study: **Higher levels of Euroskepticism are associated with higher levels of rejection of gay men and lesbian women (H1).**

4. Data and method

4.1. Sample

I used data from the European Social Survey (ESS) round 11 from 2023. The ESS is a biennial cross-sectional survey designed to study changing social attitudes and values in Europe. The Politics module includes questions on attitudes toward gay and lesbian people, as well as on perceptions of the role of the European Union and its potential enlargement. The dataset was filtered to consider observations from Serbia. The analytical sample (see Table 1) includes 1,098 respondents who provided complete data for the variables of interest. It shows a near-equal gender distribution (49% female). The average respondent is 52 years old ($SD = 17.53$), with an age range spanning from 17 to 90. In terms of educational attainment, the sample reports a mean of 12.53 years of formal schooling ($SD = 3.14$), reflecting a population that has generally completed secondary education but exhibits variation in academic background.

Demographic Characteristics of the Analytical Sample

Statistic	N	Mean	St. Dev.	Min	Max
Age	1,098	52.06	17.53	17	90
Female (Dummy)	1,098	0.49	0.50	0	1
Education (Years)	1,098	12.53	3.14	1	28

Source: European Social Survey Round 11 (2023).

Figure 2: Summary of demographic characteristics of the analytical sample. Own elaboration.

4.2. Focal variables and operationalization

The focal independent variable is an index that captures scepticism toward the European Union. It is based on three indicators: (1) the individual’s emotional attachment to Europe (atcherp), (2) whether they believe European unification should go further or has gone too

far (euftf), and (3) their level of trust in the European Parliament (trstep). While the original survey items are coded such that higher values reflect more positive attitudes toward Europe, I reversed the scales for consistency with the hypothesis of this study. In this reversed index, scores range from 0 to 10, where higher values represent higher levels of Euroskepticism. To validate the index, I first computed the items' Cronbach's alpha, obtaining a value of 0.67, which indicates acceptable internal consistency for a three-item scale in social science research. I then conducted an Exploratory Factor Analysis (EFA) to evaluate the dimensionality of the variables. Since all items loaded onto a single factor (with loadings ranging from 0.57 to 0.70), I computed a factor score representing the latent construct of Euroskepticism.

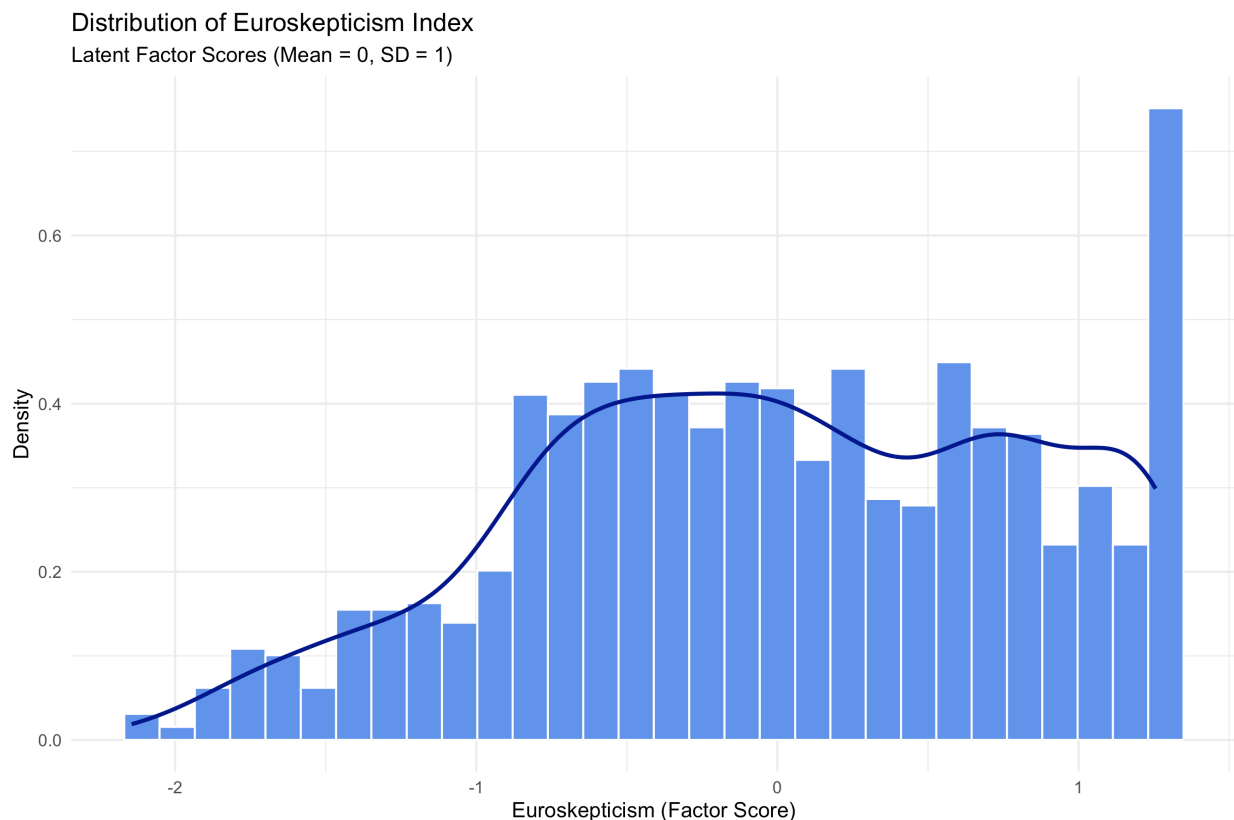


Figure 3: Distribution of focal independent variable. Own elaboration.

The distribution of Euroskepticism scores is left-skewed, with most respondents concentrated at the higher end of the scale. A significant spike at the far right indicates a large group of individuals holding the highest measured levels of skepticism toward the EU. This suggests that Euroskepticism is not only a prominent sentiment but the dominant one within the surveyed Serbian population.

The focal dependent variable is an index representing the rejection of gay men and lesbian women. This serves as an empirical proxy for homonegativity, mirroring the construction of the latent homopositivity factor using ESS items by Whitworth (2023). The index comprises three items measuring respondents' agreement with the following statements: (1) "Gays and

lesbians should be free to live their lives as they wish” (freehms), (2) “If a close family member were a gay man or lesbian, I would feel ashamed” (hmsfmlsh), and (3) “Gay male and lesbian couples should have the same rights to adopt children as straight couples” (hmsacl). Responses for the first and third items range from “Agree strongly” (1) to “Disagree strongly” (5); for these items, a value of 5 already represents the highest level of rejection. The second variable (hmsfmlsh) was reverse-coded so that its values align with the others, with higher values consistently indicating greater rejection. Following the same procedure as for the independent variable, I assessed the internal consistency of the items, which yielded a robust Cronbach’s alpha of 0.76. An Exploratory Factor Analysis (EFA) confirmed that all items loaded onto a single factor, which was then used to construct the final Rejection Index.

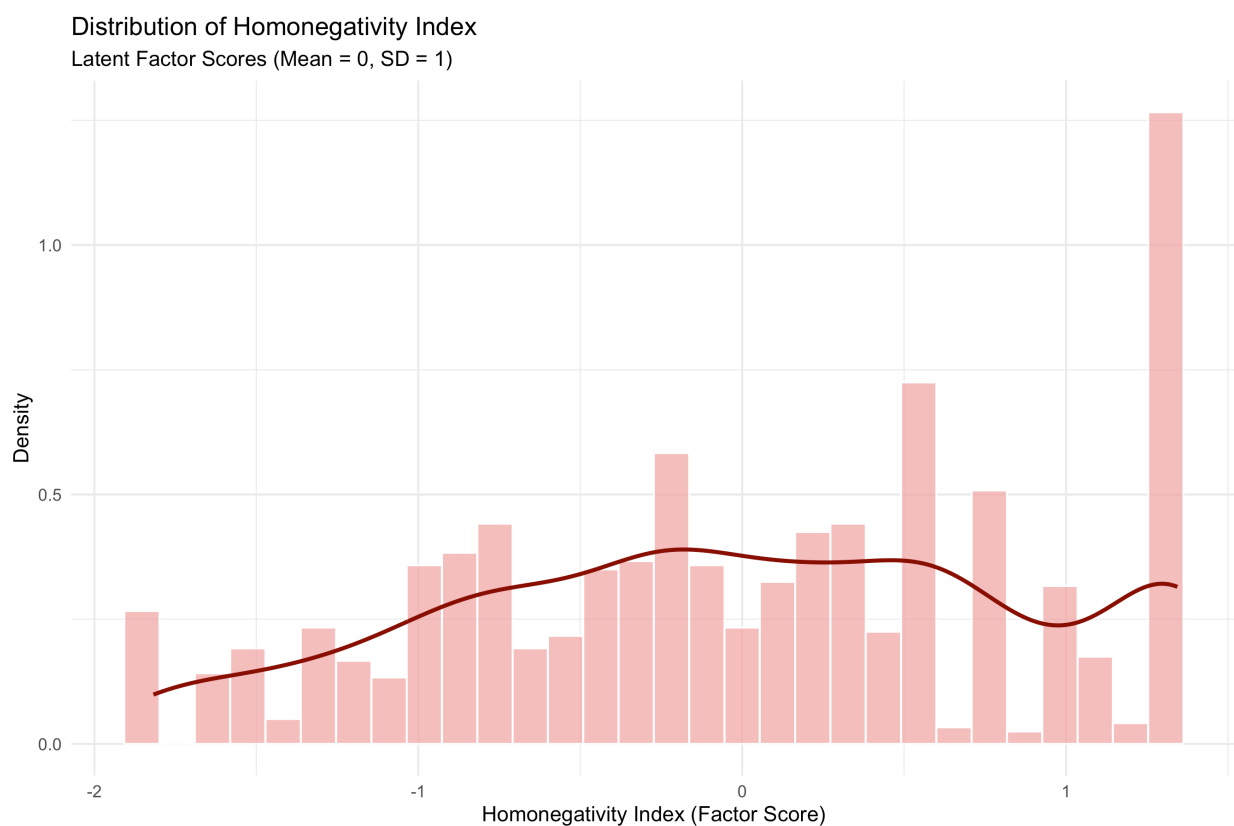


Figure 4: Distribution of focal dependent variable. Own elaboration.

The distribution of the Rejection of Gays and Lesbians Index is multi-modal, with scores spread across the entire spectrum. This indicates the sample of Serbians holds a wide variety of attitudes toward homosexuals, with several clusters emerging. Much like the distribution of the Euroskepticism Index, the spike at the right extreme represents a concentrated segment of the population that exhibits the maximum possible level of homonegativity.

To account for potential variance explained by demographic characteristics, I control for age, gender, and years of formal education. Considering the interplay between religion and nationalism in the context of discrimination against sexually diverse individuals (Juergens-

meyer, 2008; Kahlina, 2013; Sremac & Ganzevoort, 2015) religiosity was included as a control variable. It is measured on a scale from 0 to 10, where 10 indicates that the individual identifies as “very religious”.

4.3. Analytical strategy

This study utilizes the elaboration model proposed by Aneshensel (2013) to investigate the relationship between Euroskepticism and the rejection of gay men and lesbian women in Serbia. Following the establishment of a bivariate association between the focal independent and dependent variables, the analysis adopts an exclusionary approach. By systematically introducing potential confounders into the regression model, this approach seeks to rule out spuriousness and determine if the observed relationship persists when accounting for antecedent factors. Model diagnostics, including checks for linearity, normality of residuals, heteroscedasticity, multicollinearity (VIF), and influential cases (Cook’s distance), were assessed for the final model. Full code and output are available in the replication repository.

5. Results

5.1. Bivariate model

The initial step of the analysis examined the bivariate association between the focal independent and dependent variables. As illustrated by the line of best fit in Figure 5, the model reveals a positive linear relationship between skepticism toward the European Union and the rejection of gay men and lesbian women.

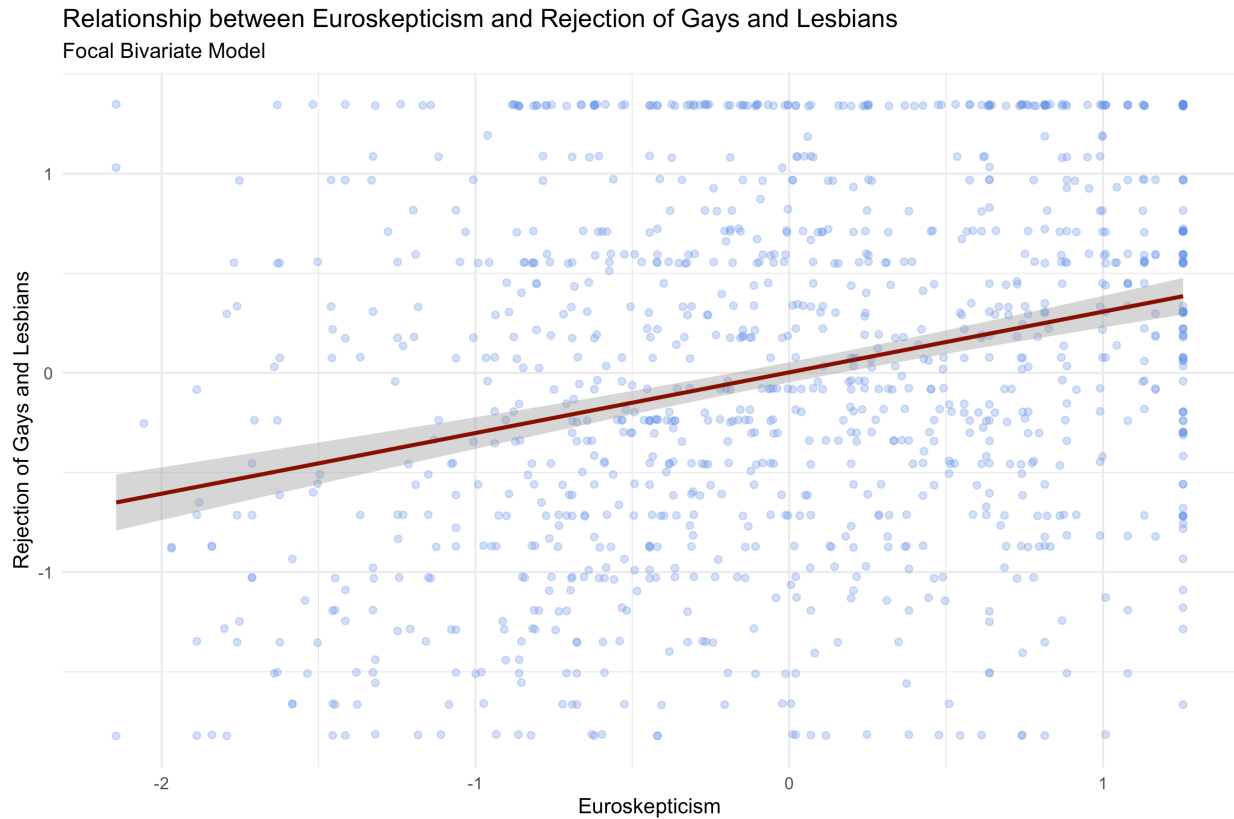


Figure 5: Bivariate association between the Euroskepticism Index and the Rejection of Gays and Lesbians Index. Own elaboration.

The results from this bivariate regression are statistically significant ($p < .001$). The model reveals a moderate positive association, wherein a one-unit increase in the Euroskepticism index predicts a 0.30-point increase on the rejection scale. With an adjusted R^2 of 0.079, skepticism toward the European Union alone explains 7.9% of the variance in the rejection of gay men and lesbian women within the Serbian context.

5.2. Exclusionary strategy

I added four control variables – age, gender, years of education, and level of religiosity – in Model 2 to produce what Aneshensel (2013) defines as the “restricted model”. As shown in the regression table, there was an increase in the Adjusted R-squared from 0.079 (7.9%) to 0.230 (23.0%), indicating that the added variables account for a significant portion of the variance in the rejection of homosexuals. According to the restricted model, Euroskepticism remains a highly significant predictor (see Figure 6), though the focal coefficient decreased from 0.304 ($p < .001$) in the bivariate model to 0.255 ($p < .001$) in the multivariate context. All control variables displayed significant effects on the dependent variable. Gender showed a strong negative association ($\beta = -0.273$, $p < .001$), indicating that women exhibit lower levels of rejection than men. Age showed a very slight positive association ($\beta = 0.007$, $p < .001$), while education had a more notable negative effect ($\beta = -0.071$, $p < .001$), suggesting that

homonegativity is more prevalent among older individuals and decreases with each additional year of schooling. Further, religiosity exhibited a considerably smaller effect ($\beta = 0.056$, $p < .001$) relative to the focal predictor ($\beta = 0.255$, $p < .001$).

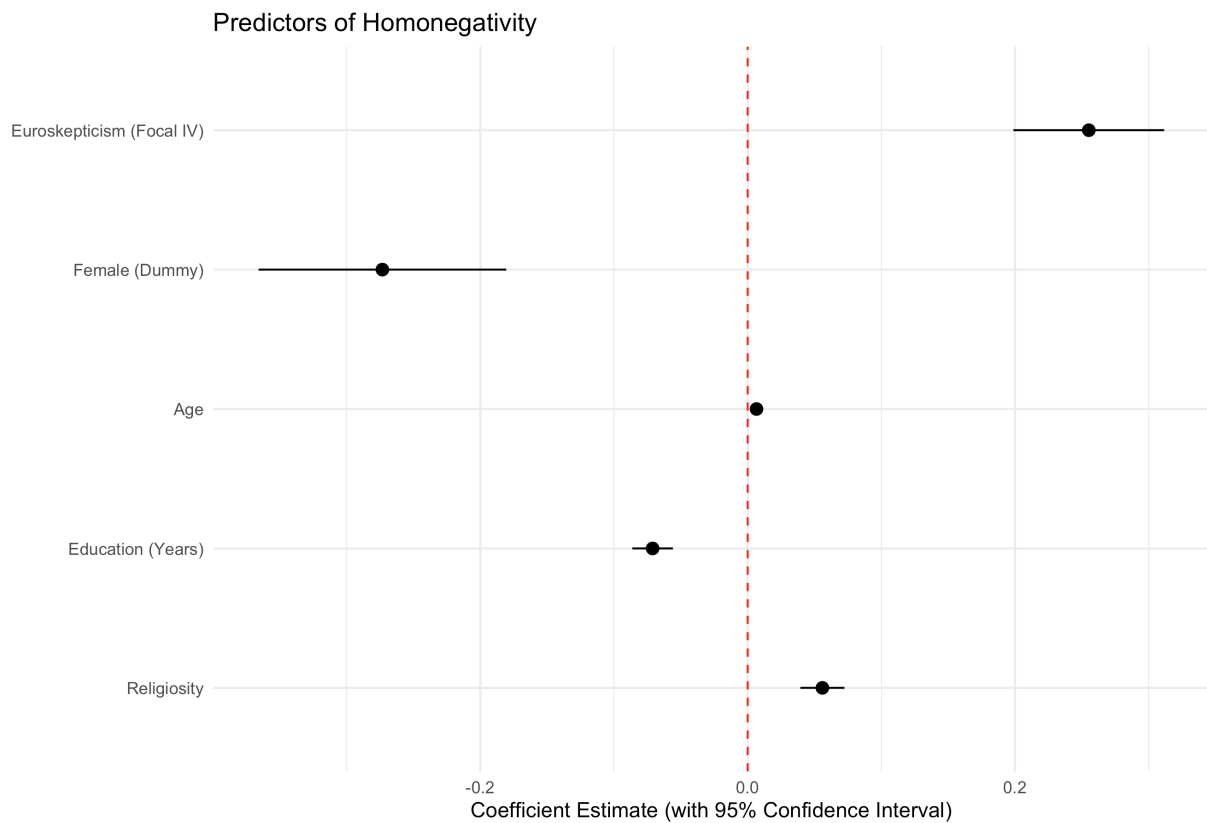


Figure 6: Forest plot showing the influence of the controls on the dependent variable. Own elaboration.

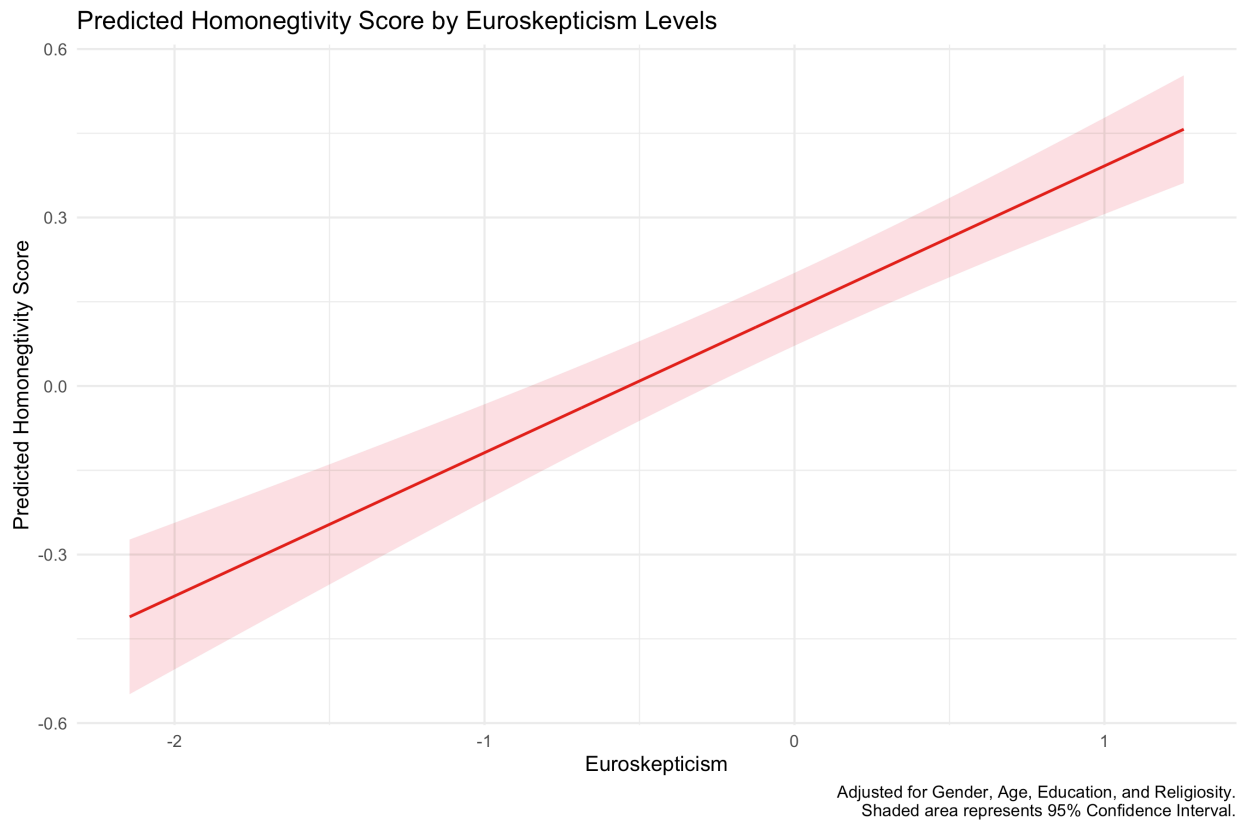


Figure 7: Linear prediction of Homonegativity Score based on Euroskepticism. Own elaboration.

No multicollinearity was detected (all VIF values ≈ 1.0), no influential cases were found to distort the regression parameters, and three outliers identified via Cook's distance were removed to stabilize the error variance. Finally, an ANOVA test comparing the two models confirmed that the inclusion of these control variables significantly improved the model's fit ($F(4, 1092) = 54.69, p < .001$). Because the introduction of control variables did not considerably reduce the focal coefficient and it remains statistically significant, the relationship is considered non-spurious. **Therefore, the null hypothesis is rejected in favor of H1: there is a positive relationship between Euroskepticism and the rejection of gays and lesbians in Serbia.**

Impact of Euroskepticism on Homonegativity in Serbia

	LG Rejection Index	
	Bivariate	Multivariate
	(1)	(2)
Euroskepticism Index	0.304*** (0.031)	0.255*** (0.029)
Gender: Female		-0.273*** (0.047)
Age (Years)		0.007*** (0.001)
Education (Years)		-0.071*** (0.008)
Religiosity		0.056*** (0.008)
Constant	0.002 (0.026)	0.338* (0.150)
N	1,098	1,098
R ²	0.080	0.234
Adjusted R ²	0.079	0.230

* p < .05; ** p < .01; *** p < .001

Source: European Social Survey Round 11 (2023).

Figure 8: Comparison of Model 1 (Bivariate) and Model 2 (Multivariate). Own elaboration.

6. Discussion

The findings suggest that sexuality has indeed become a symbolic boundary-marker in the process of EU enlargement (Slootmaeckers, 2023). The high rate of Euroskepticism suggests that for many Serbian citizens, the rejection of LGBT rights is intertwined with a perceived form of political resistance.

The multivariate analysis further elucidates the complexity of this relationship. The lower propensity for homonegativity among women confirms that the articulation between sexuality and nationalism operates through a gendered logic, where the defense of traditional heteronormativity is often more central to the performance of masculine national identity. Notably, the introduction of religiosity did not significantly erode the focal coefficient of Euroskepticism. This finding supports Maycock's (2019) argument that religiosity alone is insufficient to explain modern homonegativity in the region. Instead, it suggests that homonegativity is driven more by geopolitical alignment expressed through Cooper-Cunningham's (2021) "heteronormative internationalism". In this regard, the absence of specific ESS questions on NATO, a key factor in Serbian attitudes toward European integration, remains a critical limitation of this study. It also does not account for the specific influence of Russian media consumption, which likely mediates the "Gayropa" narrative.

On a methodological note, the study is further constrained by the inherent limitations of cross-sectional data. Without multi-wave panel data, it is impossible to measure whether externally-led EU initiatives have actively hindered efforts to achieve full social belonging for gay and lesbian citizens over time. Furthermore, the absence of longitudinal data precludes the use of fixed effects models, which are essential for controlling for unobserved time-invariant characteristics that may influence both Euroskepticism and homonegativity. While the observed associations are statistically significant and theoretically grounded, the lack of fixed effects means we cannot entirely rule out omitted variable bias, nor can we definitively establish a causal direction between the shifting geopolitical alignment and the intensification of homonegativity.

Ultimately, this study suggests that the dispute for LGBT rights in Serbia does not reside merely within the moral realm; rather, it is intermeshed with the country's geopolitical position and its historical relationship with both its Eastern and Western neighbors. The findings, viewed through Slootmaeckers' (2023) framework, underscore that the EU's self-proclaimed "rights exceptionalism" and its model of unilateral norm diffusion may contravene the goal of achieving full social belonging for gay and lesbian individuals. In the Serbian context, when sexual citizenship is perceived as an imported requirement rather than a domestic claim to participation, it remains vulnerable to being characterized as an alien imposition. Echoing Hannah Arendt (1951, as cited in Thiel, 2022, p. 20), the necessity to claim and be awarded the fundamental right of political participation precedes the "right to have rights".

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